Saryarqa Go: book Kazakhstan with confidence

An English / Chinese booking app that helps Saryarqa Routes reach 30% foreign travelers within 24 months.
Team: _____

1. Summary

Saryarqa Routes sells guided trips almost only to Kazakhstan residents because its sales process (Instagram messages, WhatsApp, phone, Kaspi or cash, a Russian-only one-page site) does not work for foreigners Case fact. Saryarqa Go is a bilingual booking app built as one closed loop (Discover, Plan, Verify, Book, Travel, Share) that answers the four complaints foreign guests actually made. We start with Chinese-speaking independent travelers. The 12-week MVP fits the 20,000,000 KZT year-1 budget and, under stated assumptions, pays back in month 32 (base) or month 44 (downside).

2. Problem and relevance

Saryarqa Routes (Astana, founded 2020; 9 staff, ~25 freelance guides) served 3,400 travelers in 2025 with revenue of 150,000,000 KZT and an average price of 44,000 KZT; about 96% were from Kazakhstan. The goal is 30% foreign travelers within 24 months Case fact. Foreign guests named four problems, and each one stops a sale before payment:

Guest said Case fact	Where the sale breaks	Root cause today
"It is unclear how to book."	Before first contact	Chat-only sales; Russian-only one-page website
"I am not sure the company is trustworthy."	Before paying abroad	No visible proof; no way to meet the people
"My foreign card does not work."	At payment	Kaspi transfer or cash only
"I do not know what is included."	Before committing	No structured description of the price

Why Chinese-speaking independent travelers first

- **Fast-growing market.** Kazakhstan received about 655,000 visitors from China in 2024, +78% vs 367,000 in 2023, according to the Ministry of Tourism and Sports [1][2] Verified source. China was the largest source market outside the near abroad in 2024 [3] Verified source.
- **No visa barrier.** A mutual visa-free regime has applied since November 2023: up to 30 days per visit, max 90 days in 180 [1] Verified source. The decision is about trust, clarity and payment, exactly the four complaints.
- **Big inbound flow overall.** Kazakhstan counted 15.3 million foreign visitors for tourism purposes in 2024 [3] and 15.7 million in the first nine months of 2025 [5] Verified source.
- **Product fit.** Nature and photography (Charyn, Kolsai, Burabay) and Silk Road culture (Turkestan) match what independent travelers look for Proposal.

Method note: an analyst estimate of 241,700 Chinese visitors in 2025 [4] uses a different method from the Ministry figure for 2024 [1], so the two are not compared. National visitor counts [3][5] and World Bank / UN Tourism overnight arrivals [6] use different definitions.

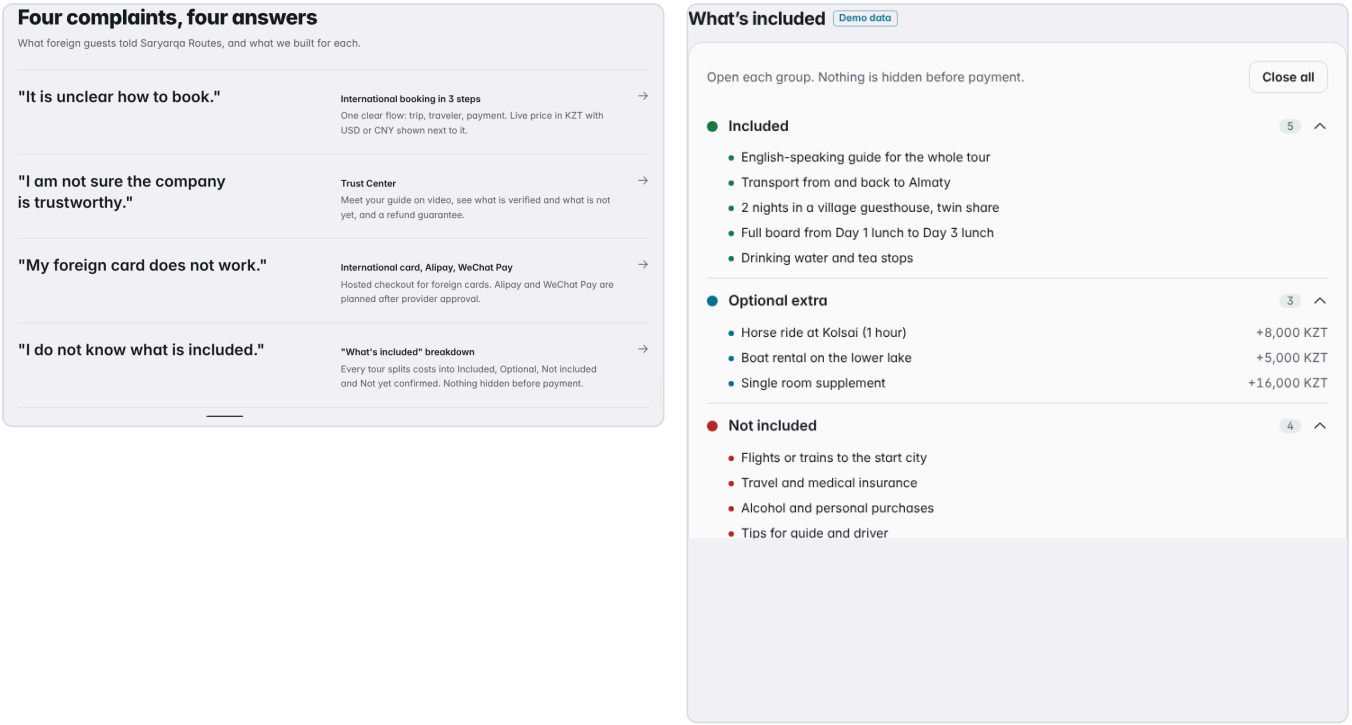
The size of the job

About 4% of 3,400 ≈ 136 travelers are foreign today. Keeping ≈ 3,264 domestic travelers, 30% foreign needs ≈ 4,663 travelers in total, so ≈ 1,399 foreign: about **1,263 more foreign travelers per year**, ≈ 105 per month. One complaint fixed at a time will not get there; the whole buying journey must work for a foreigner.

3. The product: Saryarqa Go

One closed loop instead of a pile of features. Every step removes one doubt, and the last step brings the next traveler back to the first.

Step	What the traveler gets	Complaint answered
Discover	Tour pages in EN / 中文; "What's included" in four groups: Included, Optional extra, Not included, Not yet confirmed	"I do not know what is included"
Plan	Trip builder: arrival, real tour days, Almaty / Turkestan / Astana transfers, city days, cost estimate	"It is unclear how to book"
Verify	Trust Center: guide intro video, 5-minute video call before paying, honest verification checklist, refund rules; bilingual concierge that hands off to a human when unsure	"I am not sure the company is trustworthy"
Book	Three steps (trip, lead traveler, payment); international card via the provider's hosted checkout; Alipay / WeChat Pay after provider approval; price in KZT with USD / CNY	"My foreign card does not work"; "unclear how to book"
Travel	Timeline with daily check-ins, opt-in family updates (no GPS), weather and road-closure rescheduling, audio guide in Chinese	Trust during the trip
Share	Postcard sized for Xiaohongshu / WeChat Moments with a referral link that opens step 1 for a friend	Low-cost acquisition



Prototype screens: the four complaints mapped to features (left) and the four-group "What's included" breakdown (right). Full flow and more screens in the separate flow document.

4. Originality and unique value

- **"Not yet confirmed" as a feature.** Park fees, guesthouse names, the Kaindy 4×4 transfer and Chinese-guide availability are shown openly and confirmed in writing before the trip. Honesty about the unknown is the trust signal.

- **Meet the guide before you pay.** For a traveler abroad, the guide is the company. A short video and an optional 5-minute call turn an unknown firm into a person.
- **A concierge that refuses to guess.** It answers in the traveler's language from verified tour data only and passes availability, discount and edge-case questions to a manager.
- **Safety for the family at home.** Opt-in, one trip only, ends automatically, shares check-in status rather than live location.
- **The postcard closes the loop.** Content the traveler wants to post anyway becomes the cheapest acquisition channel.
- **Honesty labels everywhere.** Every claim in the app is marked Case fact, Verified source, Proposal, Demo data or Needs confirmation.

5. Feasibility: a realistic 12-week MVP

Weeks	Work	Done when
W1-2	Research and validation; apply to payment providers	10+ traveler interviews done; applications sent
W3-4	UX and EN / 中文 tour pages	4 tour pages reviewed by 3+ target users
W5-7	Booking, inclusions, concierge, Trust Center	End-to-end test booking in payment sandbox
W8-9	Trip builder, live checkout, reschedule workflow	First real test payment by staff
W10-11	Usability tests; payment-provider checks	5-8 sessions, no blocking issue left
W12	Pilot with real travelers	Pilot metrics collected

Rule: anything that needs a third party's approval or live data waits for later (live LLM concierge, Alipay / WeChat Pay, live weather, GPS sharing, offline audio, Trip.com / Klook). The MVP therefore ships in 12 weeks regardless. **Tools:** React + TypeScript web app (reuses the prototype), managed database with admin panel, payment provider hosted checkout with webhooks. **People:** a contracted designer, two developers and a Chinese localizer, with one Saryarqa Routes staff member as product owner Proposal.

Proof: a working clickable prototype already covers the whole loop (booking with validation and a simulated declined payment, bilingual concierge, trip builder, trust center, in-trip screen, postcard, live payback calculator). An automated test checks 75 acceptance points, including phone width and dark mode; all pass. Payments are simulated in the prototype (TEST MODE); no card or passport data is collected.

6. Costs, payback and impact

20.0M KZT	13,200 KZT	Month 32	Month 44
year-1 budget (12.0M one-time)	contribution per traveler	payback, base case	payback, downside (× 0.7)

Revenue comes from the margin on additional foreign travelers (44,000 KZT × 30% assumed margin) Proposal. Break-even needs 1,516 extra foreign travelers in total. Payback falls inside 48 months for any margin of 20% or more in the base case; the downside needs about 30% or more. Full budget, revenue model, yearly cash flow and sensitivity are in the separate financial document.

Impact Proposal: a second, foreign revenue stream for the company beside its domestic base; travelers get clear prices, their own payment method and a guide they have met; Kazakhstan gets an easy-to-book, trustworthy experience that Chinese travelers share on their own social platforms, spreading demand to regions beyond the big cities.

7. Risks and how we reduce them

Risk	Mitigation
Alipay / WeChat Pay approval slow or refused	Launch with international cards via hosted checkout; apply in week 1; manager-assisted payment as fallback
Concierge gives a wrong answer	Verified data only, visible labels, "I won't guess" rule with human hand-off, weekly log review
Low demand from Chinese travelers	Interviews before building; small pilot; test Xiaohongshu content and postcards before paid ads
Cross-border data and privacy	Minimum data (no passport, no card numbers); legal review; family sharing off by default
Guides' Chinese is not good enough	Language test; interpreter partners; "Not yet confirmed" until checked; Chinese audio guide as backup

Still to verify before launch **Needs confirmation**: business registration, operator licence and insurance documents; park and site fees; payment-provider terms; the 30% margin against real costs.

Budget, revenue model and payback

All figures in KZT. Planning assumptions are labelled; case facts come from the official brief.

1. Business model

Who pays: foreign travelers pay Saryarqa Routes for guided trips booked through the app. The app is not sold to anyone; it is a sales channel that turns foreign interest into paid bookings.

Revenue stream	How it works	In the model?
Margin on additional foreign travelers	Average price 44,000 KZT Case fact × contribution margin 30% Proposal = 13,200 KZT per traveler, after direct tour costs and payment fees	Yes, the only revenue counted
Optional extras	Horse rides, boats, single rooms, photo sessions sold on the tour page	No (upside)
Multi-tour trips	Trip builder combines tours, raising spend per traveler	No (upside)
Referrals	Postcard links bring friends at low acquisition cost	No (upside)

Only one stream is counted so the result is conservative. Note: 150,000,000 ÷ 3,400 = 44,118 KZT, slightly above the stated 44,000 KZT average; the model uses 44,000.

2. Budget: development, launch and maintenance

Block	Item	Type	KZT
Development	Design and development	one-time	8,000,000
	Localization EN / 中文	one-time	1,500,000
	Payment integration and testing	one-time	1,500,000
	Trust content: guide videos, photos	one-time	1,000,000
Launch	Marketing and acquisition (Xiaohongshu, WeChat, partners)	year 1	4,500,000
	Pilot and support	year 1	1,000,000
Maintenance	Hosting, AI usage, maintenance	year 1	1,500,000
Reserve	Contingency	year 1	1,000,000
Total year 1 (case limit: up to 20,000,000 KZT Case fact)			**20,000,000**

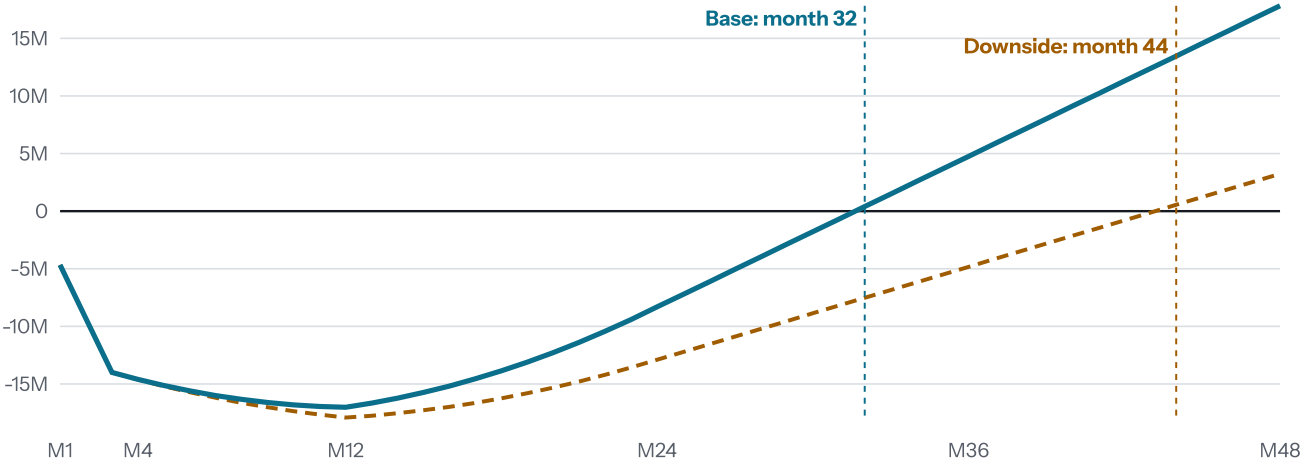
After year 1, running costs (hosting, support, marketing upkeep) are assumed at **300,000 KZT per month = 3,600,000 KZT per year** Proposal. All budget lines are planning assumptions Proposal to be confirmed with at least two quotes.

3. Volume assumption

Goal: 30% foreign travelers within 24 months Case fact. Today ≈ 136 foreign travelers (4% of 3,400). Keeping ≈ 3,264 domestic travelers, 30% foreign means ≈ 4,663 total and ≈ 1,399 foreign, so **≈ 1,263 additional foreign travelers per year** by month 24. Launch is in month 4; volume ramps linearly from launch to the full run rate in month 24 (month *m* gets (m − 3) ÷ 21 of it), then stays flat.

4. Payback model

Formula. Monthly net = additional travelers × 13,200 − costs. Costs: 12.0M one-time spread over months 1-3; the other 8.0M over months 1-12; 300,000 per month from month 13. Payback = first month in which cumulative cash is ≥ 0. **Downside scenario:** 30% fewer travelers than planned (× 0.7), everything else unchanged.



Cumulative cash over 48 months. Solid: base case. Dashed: downside (travelers × 0.7).

Year	Add. travelers (base)	Contribution	Costs	Net	Cumulative base	Cumulative downside
Year 1	226	3.0M	20.0M	-17.0M	-17.0M	-17.9M
Year 2	932	12.3M	3.6M	8.7M	-8.3M	-12.9M
Year 3	1,263	16.7M	3.6M	13.1M	4.8M	-4.8M
Year 4	1,263	16.7M	3.6M	13.1M	17.8M	3.2M

Results

	Base	Downside
Lowest cumulative cash	-17.0M	-17.9M
Cumulative cash, month 24	-8.3M	-12.9M
Payback month	**32**	**44**
Cumulative cash, month 48	17.8M	3.2M
Break-even travelers (20M ÷ 13,200)	1,516	1,516

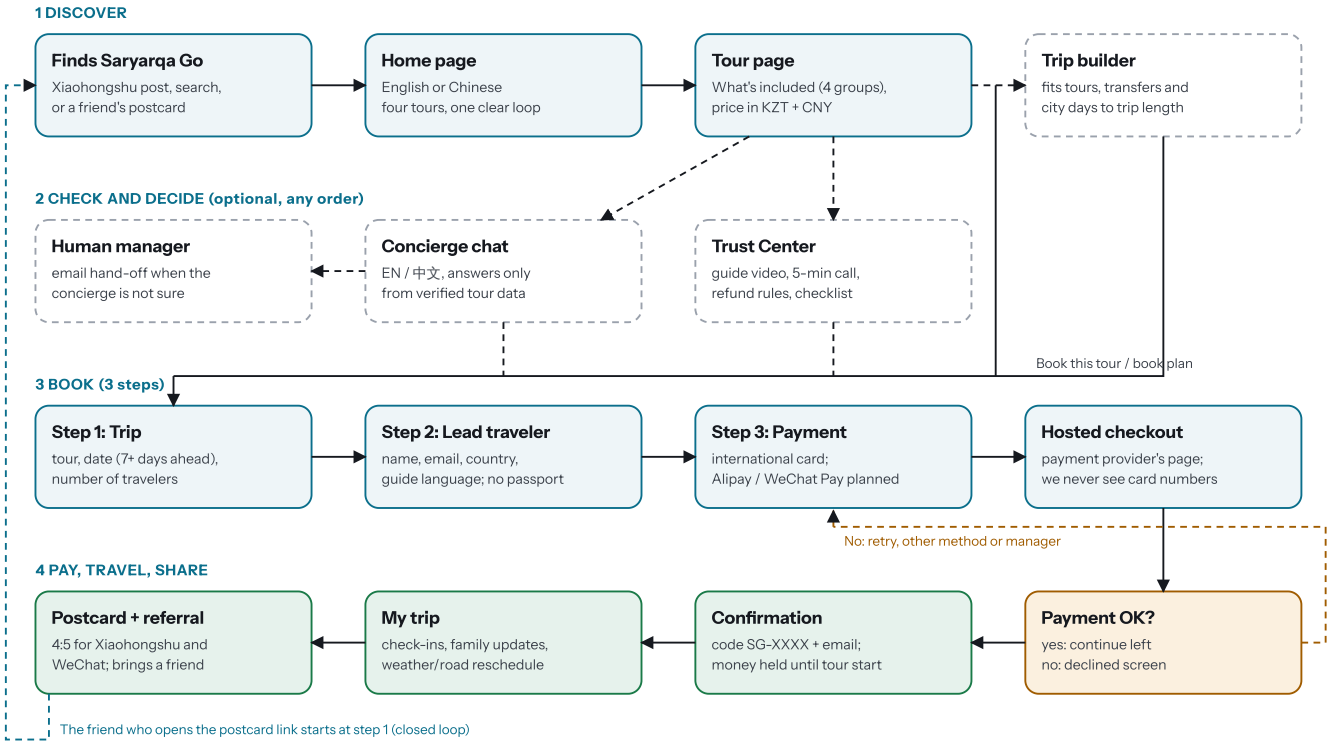
Sensitivity to the margin assumption

Margin	Payback base	Payback downside
20%	month 46	> 48 months
25%	month 37	> 48 months
30% (default)	month 32	month 44
35%	month 29	month 38
40%	month 27	month 34

Reading it honestly. The base case pays back within 48 months for any margin from 20% up. The downside needs a margin of about 30% or more, so the margin is the first number to check with the company's real costs. If the pilot shows weaker demand, the levers are: shift marketing to referrals and organic Xiaohongshu content, delay paid ads, and keep running costs at the 300,000 KZT per month floor. The model is also live and adjustable on the Impact page of the prototype.

How a foreign traveler goes from search to payment

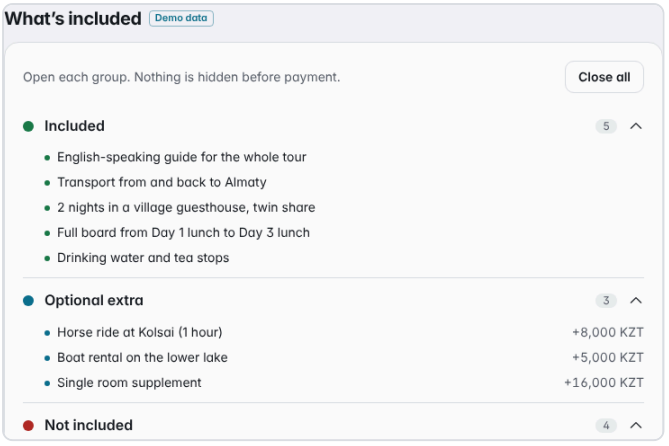
Solid boxes are the main path. Dashed boxes are optional checks the traveler can use in any order before booking.



Step	What happens	Doubt removed
1. Discover	Lands from a Xiaohongshu post, search or a friend's postcard; switches to 中文; opens a tour	"Unclear how to book"; "what is included"
2. Check and decide	Optional: trip builder, concierge in Chinese (hand-off to a manager if unsure), Trust Center with guide video and a 5-minute call	"Is this company trustworthy?"
3. Book	Three short steps with clear inline errors; price summary repeats Included and Not-yet-confirmed items	"Unclear how to book"
4. Pay, travel, share	Provider-hosted card checkout; declined payments can be retried; confirmation code; trip timeline; postcard with referral link	"My foreign card does not work"

Key screens of the working prototype

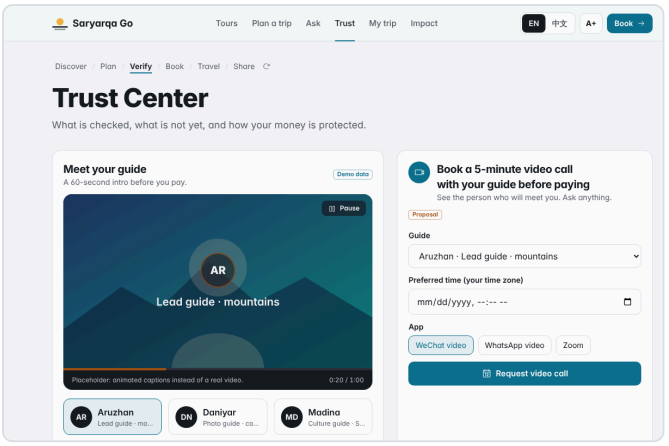
Screens from the clickable prototype (dist/index.html). Tour details and prices are demo data; payments are simulated (TEST MODE).



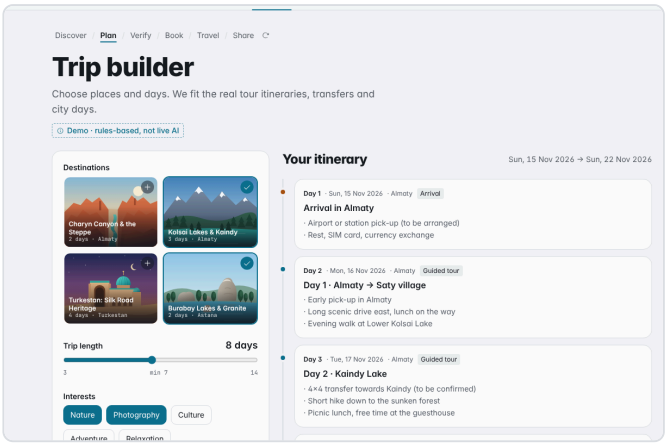
1. Tour page: "What's included" in four groups.



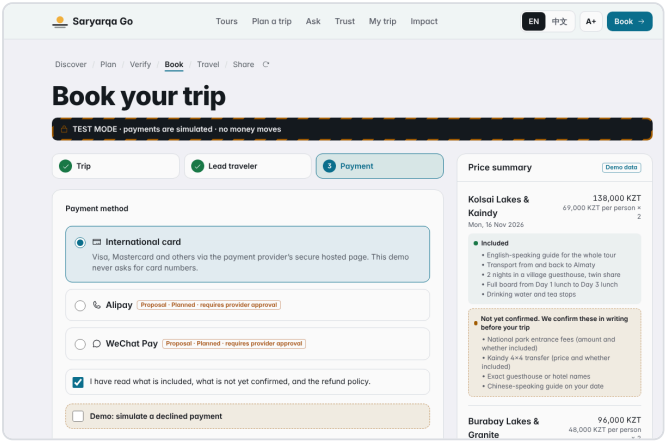
2. Concierge answering in Chinese, opened from the tour page.



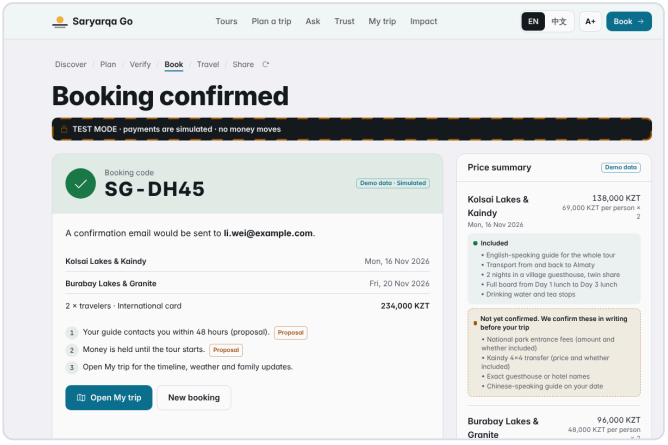
3. Trust Center: guide intro, video-call request, honest checklist.



4. Trip builder: 8 days, Kolsai + Burabay, transfer to Astana.



5. Booking step 3: international card; Alipay / WeChat Pay planned.



6. Confirmation with booking code.

Sources of statistics and facts

Accessed 25 October 2026. The team opens every link again before submission. Numbers in [brackets] are used in the main report.

[1] The Times of Central Asia (19 June 2025). Article on the launch of the 2025 Year of China Tourism in Kazakhstan, citing the Ministry of Tourism and Sports of the Republic of Kazakhstan. 655,000 visitors from China in 2024 (+78% vs 367,000 in 2023); mutual visa-free regime since November 2023, up to 30 days per visit, max 90 days in 180.
https://timesca.com/kazakhstan-launches-2025-year-of-china-tourism/

[2] The Astana Times (February 2025). *Tourist Numbers from China to Kazakhstan Surge 78% in 2024.* Corroborates the 2024 figure.
https://astanatimes.com/2025/02/tourist-numbers-from-china-to-kazakhstan-surge-78-in-2024/

[3] The Astana Times (June 2025). *Who's Visiting Kazakhstan? These Five Countries Top List*, citing the Tourism Industry Committee. 15.3 million foreign visitors for tourism purposes in 2024; China first outside the near abroad with 655,000.
https://astanatimes.com/2025/06/whos-visiting-kazakhstan-these-five-countries-top-list/

[4] Orda.kz, citing Energyprom.kz analysts. *Chinese Tourist Arrivals in Kazakhstan Rose Sharply in 2025, Analysts Say.* 241,700 Chinese citizens in 2025 (+38.9%); Russia 429,800. Different method from [1]; not compared directly.
https://en.orda.kz/chinese-tourist-arrivals-in-kazakhstan-rose-sharply-in-2025-analysts-say-10111/

[5] The Astana Times (February 2026). *Kazakhstan Reports Tourism Growth Surge as Visitor Numbers and Revenues Climb in 2025.* 15.7 million foreign visitors for tourism purposes in the first nine months of 2025, excluding labour migrants and permanent residents.
https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/kazakhstan-reports-tourism-growth-surge-as-visitor-numbers-and-revenues-climb-in-2025/

[6] World Bank. *International tourism, number of arrivals (ST.INT.ARVL), Kazakhstan.* Data from UN Tourism (World Tourism Organization), CC BY 4.0. Counts overnight inbound visitors; not comparable with national visitor counts.
https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/ST.INT.ARVL?locations=KZ

[7] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms of the Republic of Kazakhstan. *Tourism statistics: dynamic tables* ("Number of inbound tourism visitors"; "Incoming visitors served, by nationality"). Official series for checking the figures above.
https://stat.gov.kz/en/industries/businessstatistics/stat-tourism/dynamic-tables/

[8] ZERTTEX Hackathon 2026, Stage 1, Case 1 "Technology Product": company facts for Saryarqa Routes (fictional case company), complaints from foreign guests, goal and budget.

> Everything not taken from these sources is labelled in the report and the prototype as Proposal, Demo data or Needs confirmation. Tour prices, guide profiles, weather and road data in the prototype are demo data.

Use of artificial intelligence

Completed honestly by the team. Edit the bracketed fields before submission.

Level of AI use

Part of the submission	AI use	What the AI did / what people did
Prototype code (web app, logic, tests)	**High**	AI wrote the code from the team's written brief and also wrote and ran the automated tests. The team defined the product, features, case facts, honesty rules and the payback model logic.
Main report, financial document, flow diagram	**High** (first draft)	AI produced first drafts, tables and the diagram from the team's brief; numbers are calculated by code from the stated assumptions. The team reviewed, edited and is responsible for the final text.
Product idea, target market, assumptions	**Low**	Chosen by the team (target market, features, 30% margin, budget split). AI pointed out risks and inconsistencies.
Sources and statistics	**Medium**	Facts come from the case and published sources. AI ran web searches to cross-check them and found one correction (15.7 million refers to the first nine months of 2025). The team re-opens every link.
Images	**None generated**	No AI-generated images or photos. Illustrations are simple vector drawings written as code; screenshots are of the prototype.

Tools

Tool	Used for	Link to chat / session
Claude (Anthropic), via Claude Code on the web	Writing the prototype code and automated tests; building the PDFs and Word report; drafting text; web search to cross-check sources	claude.ai/code/session_01HrYY9Y9MwxQVFQRES5YEHH
[Other AI tools used by the team, if any]	[purpose]	[link]

What AI did not do

- It did not invent statistics, interviews, reviews, licences, insurance, partnerships or awards. Unproven items are labelled "Needs confirmation".
- It did not take decisions for the team: the idea, market, scope and assumptions are the team's.
- No real payments, card numbers or personal data were processed; payments in the prototype are simulated.

We confirm that this declaration describes our use of AI accurately.

Team name and members

Date